



FITNESSWISE

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‘Culture’ – the most misused word in high-performance organisations

From mottos to mindsets, the culture of high-performance organisations is one of the most **crucial elements** that define their success.

“The strength of the team is each individual member. The strength of each member is the team” — Phil Jackson

In any high-performance organisation worldwide, or in any sport, the term most frequently heard is — ‘culture’.

Often, it's used by those outside the system to explain why certain teams consistently experience success or failure compared to others.

There are numerous definitions of ‘culture’, ranging from ideas, customs, goals, attitudes, ethics, and social behaviour of a particular people or society.

Regardless of these definitions, one thing is abundantly clear: **when organisations have a poor culture, they are desperate for change, and when they have a very strong one, they want to ‘protect and preserve’ everything that contributes to its strength!**

Clear communication with a consistent message is a key factor in any professional organisation, where most professionals expect clarity and coherence.

One of the primary attributes of organisations with a strong culture is clarity regarding acceptable behaviours, how people are treated, and the way individuals carry out their daily duties.

In Malcolm Gladwell’s book, *David and Goliath*, he emphasises the significance of clear communication from leaders. He suggests that people want to know whether:

1. Yesterday’s rules are the same today
2. The rules that apply to someone else are the same that apply to them
3. If the rules change, they want to be told!

When you step into any high-performance facility worldwide, the team’s motto will be prominently displayed on the wall. This motto is meant to describe the organisation’s structure, operations, and processes, and is ingrained into the fabric of the organisation. Often, this

mantra permeates every aspect of the organisation, evident as soon as you enter the building and felt in interactions with staff and players. In contrast, organisations with a poor culture have a distinct smell — more of a stench. The signs of a poor culture are immediately apparent:

- Poor staff communication
- Gossip about team members
- Staff feeling marginalised
- Uncoordinated protocols
- Appearances over results
- Players cutting corners
- Branded attire over performance
- Disrespecting teammates/staff
- Style over substance

The issues mentioned above are merely the tip of the iceberg; deeper and more toxic issues remain hidden beneath the surface. It’s easy to point fingers at a single staff member or a specific individual in management.

Having said that, it’s possible that an individual with a toxic disposition, who holds significant decision-making power, may not align with the organisation’s culture.

While this individual may possess the requisite skills for the job, their abrasive personality can adversely impact the entire culture, setting unrealistic and unscalable standards over time for both the team and staff.